MAP HISTORIAN INDEPENDENT STUDY PROGRAM

Cantino Planisphere (1502) — Activity Cards

Choose any tier, in any order • Each card blends story, tasks, and reflection

🟢 EASY TIER — "First Contact"

📖 The Story

The Cantino Planisphere announces itself with color and confidence. Painted on six parchment sheets and measuring roughly 105 x 220 cm, this was a luxury object designed to impress a duke. A thick vertical line — the Line of Tordesillas — divides the Atlantic, declaring that Portugal and Spain have carved up the globe between them.

✅ Study Checklist

- ☐ Find a high-resolution image online (try the Biblioteca Estense Modena digital archive)
- ☐ Locate the Line of Tordesillas — note where it falls relative to Brazil and Africa
- ☐ Identify the three major landmasses: Africa, Indian subcontinent, and the Americas
- ☐ Look for flags planted on coastlines — what do they signal about territorial claims?
- ☐ Read a short overview article on the Treaty of Tordesillas (1494)

✍️ Journal Prompts

1. The real cartographer risked his life and received no credit. What does it say about who gets to 'own' discovery?

2. If you were Duke Ercole d'Este receiving this stolen map in 1502, what would you feel holding it — power, fear, wonder?

🟡 MEDIUM TIER — "Reading Between the Lines"

📖 The Story

Look closer and the Cantino begins to whisper its contradictions. Africa's coastline is remarkably accurate, while the Americas trail off into speculation and blank parchment — a continent caught mid-revelation. Meanwhile the Indian Ocean sits open and navigable, quietly burying Ptolemy's 1,400-year-old geographical error without fanfare.

✅ Study Checklist

- ☐ Compare accuracy of African vs. American coastlines — where does confidence end and guesswork begin?
- ☐ Find the Indian Ocean and compare it to a Ptolemaic map — note the dramatic difference
- ☐ Catalog at least 5 illustrated elements (animals, ships, flags, trees) and research what each symbolized
- ☐ Locate Greenland — note how it is depicted vs. actual geography
- ☐ Research the Treaty of Tordesillas: who negotiated it, why the Pope was involved, and how Portugal used it to claim Brazil

✍️ Journal Prompts

1. The map buries Ptolemy's error almost silently — no fanfare, just a correctly drawn open ocean. When has a long-held belief been quietly overturned for you by new evidence?

2. The illustrations of animals and lush landscapes were 'marketing.' What modern equivalents exist — ways we use visuals to make places seem abundant and desirable?

🔴 DIFFICULT TIER — "The Detective's Case File"

📖 The Story

Here the Cantino becomes a genuine historical puzzle. How much did Portugal actually know, and when? The North American coastline hints at secret, unrecorded voyages. The 1755 Lisbon earthquake may have destroyed the evidence forever. And the anonymous cartographer — a royal traitor for 12 gold ducats — committed treason for reasons history never recorded. The map was later found decorating a butcher's shop.

✅ Study Checklist

□ Research the Corte-Real expeditions (1500–1502) and their connection to the North American coastline on the Cantino

□ Read about the 1755 Lisbon earthquake and its destruction of Portuguese historical records

□ Trace the Cantino's provenance: Ferrara → butcher's shop → Modena

□ Compare the Cantino to the Waldseemüller Map (1507) — how did geographical knowledge evolve in just 5 years?

□ Examine cartouche and heraldic symbols — what do they communicate about Portuguese imperial identity?

□ Optional deep dive: explore Library of Congress resources on early exploration cartography

✍️ Journal Prompts

1. The anonymous cartographer committed treason for knowledge — or money, or principle. As a lifelong learner, what do you think drove him? What would you have done in his position?

2. The map nearly perished in a butcher's shop. What does the fragility of historical evidence make you feel about what we think we know — and what may be lost forever?

3. The Cantino captured the world at a moment of radical cognitive disruption. When have you experienced something that forced you to redraw your own internal map?

🤖 Copy-Paste Prompt — Deep Dive Explorer

Paste the prompt below directly into a new Claude conversation to go deeper on this map's Difficult Tier themes:

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You are a Portuguese royal historian and forensic cartographer specializing in
the Age of Discovery. I am investigating the Cantino Planisphere (1502) as a
historical detective. Help me work through three unsolved mysteries: (1) Who was
the anonymous cartographer — what can we deduce about his identity, training,
and motivations from the map itself and the historical record? (2) What does the
North American coastline on the Cantino reveal about possible secret Portuguese
voyages before John Cabot's celebrated 1497 expedition? Present the strongest
evidence on both sides of the debate. (3) How did the 1755 Lisbon earthquake
reshape what we can ever know about Portugal's Age of Discovery — what was
likely lost, and how do historians work around that silence? For each mystery,
give me the best available evidence, the key scholarly disagreements, and what
remains permanently unknowable. Treat me as a serious student who wants depth,
not a summary.
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